

Col R.P. Suhag, 56, Delta Group

Specialisation: Security services

Number of employees: 10,000

Revenues: Rs 50 crore per annum

THEN: In 1998, Col Suhag took voluntary retirement and started Delta Guards with 60 people. It was later empanelled with the Directorate-General of Resettlement.

NOW: Malls account for about 30 per cent of Delta's business. Services range from crisis and facility management to fire safety. The biggest challenge for Suhag is to ensure that there are no untoward incidents. Says Suhag, "You never know what's going on in the human mind."



SIPRA DAS

eight months. He now wants to extend the service to social networking so mall-goers can communicate and meet at designated points.

All this shows how developing specialised products and services is critical for the entrepreneurs' success. "Earlier there was no demand for such products. Today it's a necessity," says Anshuman Magazine, CMD of CB Richard Ellis, South Asia. "Often people want to be taken care of when they come into a mall and that does not always happen." Kool Kids, a mall crèche provider, is looking to change that. It provides playzones for kids under seven years old in malls so parents can drop off their kids before going to shop or watch movies. "We've seen that the amount of time people spend in the mall increases substantially with the provision of childcare facilities," says Manish Newar, managing director of Kool Kids. Of course, the longer they stay the more they spend. Newar has opened 16 play areas, almost doubling the number of outlets in one-and-a-half years. He lures parents and kids with bright colours and a promise of safety, and plans to operate more than 27 playzones by year end. The key to his rapid growth: a highly-opportunistic business model that relies on aggressive marketing by mall management, creative apparel sourcing,

Manish Newar, 39

Kool Kids

Specialisation: Playzones

Number of employees: 72

Revenues: Rs 4.5 crore per annum

THEN: Newar started in 2003 in a single mall when he felt there was nothing to entertain his kids when he and his wife went out.

NOW: He has crèches in 16 malls nationwide with activities ranging from computer games to rock-climbing walls.



ISHAN TANKHA

and virtually no advertising. "They are one of the most happening outfits in the mall," says Select Citywalk's Sinha.

But where the opportunities are the ripest, the field is often jam-packed with competition—many of who are fly-by-night operators who offer their services at half the cost. Consider the private security business. Suhag estimates there are 15,000 to 20,000 such agencies in Delhi alone. With a security agency seemingly around every corner, how do you reinvent this business? Eventually, it is the quality of service and execution that will be the ultimate differentiator and help one rise above the crowd.

Yet investors haven't been too forthcoming. Save for a few companies like Telibrahma—which received Rs 1.5 crore from a local venture capital (vc) firm or Express Housekeepers and N. Sathyanarayanan's Central Parking Services—a parking solutions company that has also elicited interest from vc firms, raising funds hasn't been a cakewalk. According to Singhal, it is because of the fear that entrepreneurs would be able to take the business only up to a regional level and no further. Some of today's highfliers could crash in the future as they misread consumers, expand too quickly, or stumble in other ways. But for the persevering, the sky is the limit. ■